

Reading the Exemplars

What three well-typeset reports do that a word processor does not, and what we took from each

Design research pass, August 2026

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Set in the **Review** style. Grid, palette, furniture and every element used below are specified in docs/styles/review.md; the principles they implement are in docs/report-design-principles.md.

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SUMMARY

———— Three reports, three different answers, and none of the differences are about fonts.

The finding

Comparing the Civilization Research Institute's *Reality Check*, the Mindfulness Initiative's *Reconnection* and the Planetary Civics Inquiry's *A New Framework for Planetary Futures* page by page shows that they agree on almost nothing at the level of choice — one justifies and two do not, one uses three type families and one uses one, one has a worked left margin and one has an empty right third — and agree almost completely at the level of discipline.

What they share is that each has decided what its pages say about themselves, and then repeated that decision without variation for between 46 and 96 pages. The professional look is the consistency, not the choices.

What follows

Section 01 sets out the page furniture each report carries. Section 02 covers the grid, and in particular what a wide margin has to be doing to avoid reading as a mistake.

01

Page Furniture

Ask what the repeating, non-content elements on a page are and the three exemplars answer with confidence and at length. Ask the same question of an untreated word-processor export and the answer is a centred page number. This is the largest single difference between the two, and it is almost entirely independent of typeface.

The furniture is what a page says about itself when it has been separated from its document — photocopied, screenshotted, pulled out of a folder eighteen months later. At minimum a reader needs to know where they are, what this is, and which part of it they are holding.

The masthead, wordmark, rail folio and mono-dated footer on this page are the Review style's answer, specified in full in docs/styles/review.md §4.

What each report carries

The three sets are strikingly unequal in size, and all three work.

Reality Check, on every page

- a wordmark at the top of the left rail — letterspaced, grey, three lines
- a two-line masthead centred above the text column: publisher in bold, report title beneath
- the folio at the foot of the rail, set deliberately large in light grey
- a centred footer of publication date in mono, a pipe, and the current section name in bold sans

Reconnection carries exactly one element — a right-aligned footer giving title, subtitle and folio — and it is no less convincing, because it is identical on all 87 pages. The Planetary Civics paper does the most unusual thing: its footer is a colophon, a mono key/value block naming the page, title, date and authors, so that any single sheet identifies itself completely.

Source:
Jastrow, 1899

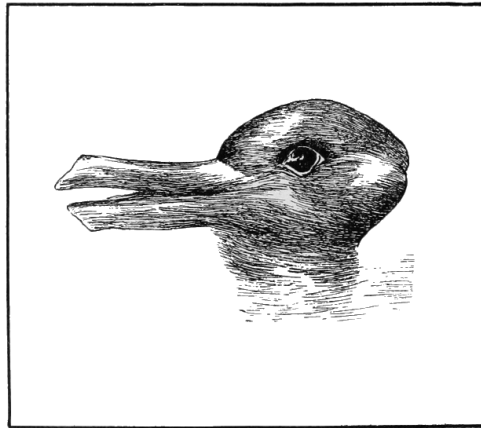


FIG. 01 Furniture is a framing device: it tells the reader what kind of thing they are looking at before they read a word. The same page with institutional furniture and with none is read differently, in the same way the same drawing is read as a duck or a rabbit depending on what you were told to expect.

The rule that follows

Decide the set once, in the spec, and then never vary it. Variation is what reads as amateur; repetition is what reads as expensive. The corollary is worth stating because it is where templates usually fail:

Furniture survives inversions. The dark full-bleed summary page in *Reality Check* keeps every piece of furniture, reversed out in the same positions. A dark page that drops the folio reads as a mistake; one that keeps it reads as design.

— docs/report-design-principles.md, principle 1

The summary page in this document is built the same way, which is the only honest way to check the claim.

The Grid

All three exemplars break the centred single column, and each breaks it differently. The interesting part is not that they are asymmetric but that each asymmetry is justified by something.

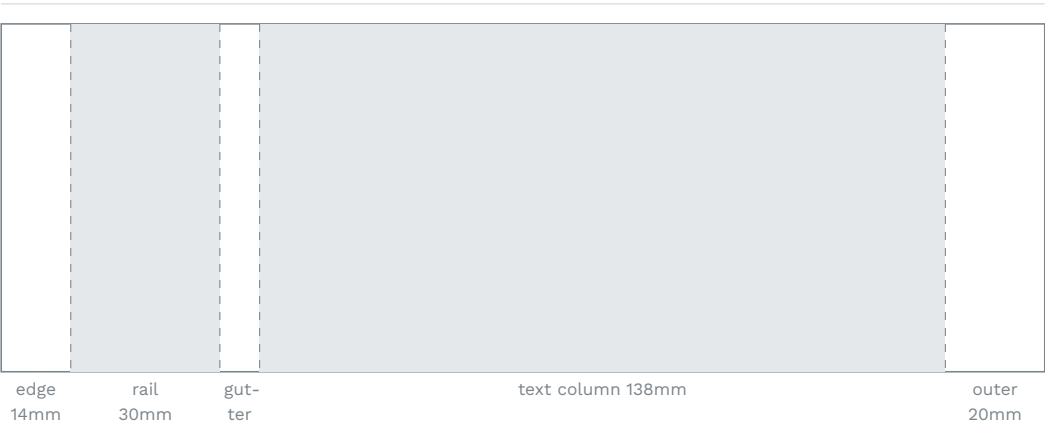


FIG. 02 The Review grid at A4. The shaded bands carry content; the two margins and the gutter never do. Because the rail is 30mm and the outer margin 20mm, the text block sits visibly right of centre — which is what makes the rail read as a column rather than as slack.

Three positions on the same problem

Report	What the wide margin does	Measure
<i>Reality Check</i>	Works it — sources, figure topics, wordmark, folio	c. 77 ch
<i>Reconnection</i>	Explains it — chapter openers span it, body pages do not	c. 72 ch
<i>Planetary Futures</i>	Commits to it — the right third is never used	c. 65 ch

Character counts
measured from
rendered pages at
80dpi, not taken from
the publishers.

The failure case is the fourth option: a wide margin that is empty, unexplained and moderate. That reads as a broken layout rather than as air, and it is what an earlier version of this template did with a 53mm left margin inherited from a designer reference and then left blank.

What we took

The Review style's grid, and why

- a 30mm rail at 14mm from the page edge, because rail material needs to be a column, not an indent
- an 8mm gutter that is always empty, because a rail without a gutter is a two-column layout
- a 138mm text column, giving about 74 characters — the top of the comfortable range, which is where *Reality Check* sits
- a 20mm outer margin, narrower than the rail side, so the page reads as pushed right rather than centred



FIG. 03 A wide figure pushes left into the rail to run the full 176mm. When it does, the source credit moves below the caption and ranges right, because the rail is occupied.

Source: *Life Itself*

Measure first

Everything above is downstream of one decision. Choose a measure between 60 and 75 characters and a leading to go with it, and the rest of the grid — column width, margins, where the rail can go — is determined. Choosing margins first and discovering the measure afterwards is how a page ends up at 90 characters, which no amount of good typeface choice will rescue.

Notes

- 1 Civilization Research Institute, Reality Check, January 2025. 96pp, Letter. Freight Text Pro / Freight Sans / SF Mono. <https://civilizationresearchinstitute.org/>
- 2 The Mindfulness Initiative, Reconnection: Meeting the Climate Crisis Inside Out. 87pp, A4. Oxygen / ITC Avant Garde. <https://www.themindfulnessinitiative.org/>
- 3 Planetary Civics Inquiry, A New Framework for Planetary Futures, April 2024. 46pp, A4. Inter / DM Mono.
- 4 Fonts read out of each PDF with pdffonts; grids and sizes measured from pages rendered at 80dpi with pdftoppm. Page-level readings are recorded in docs/report-design-principles.md.